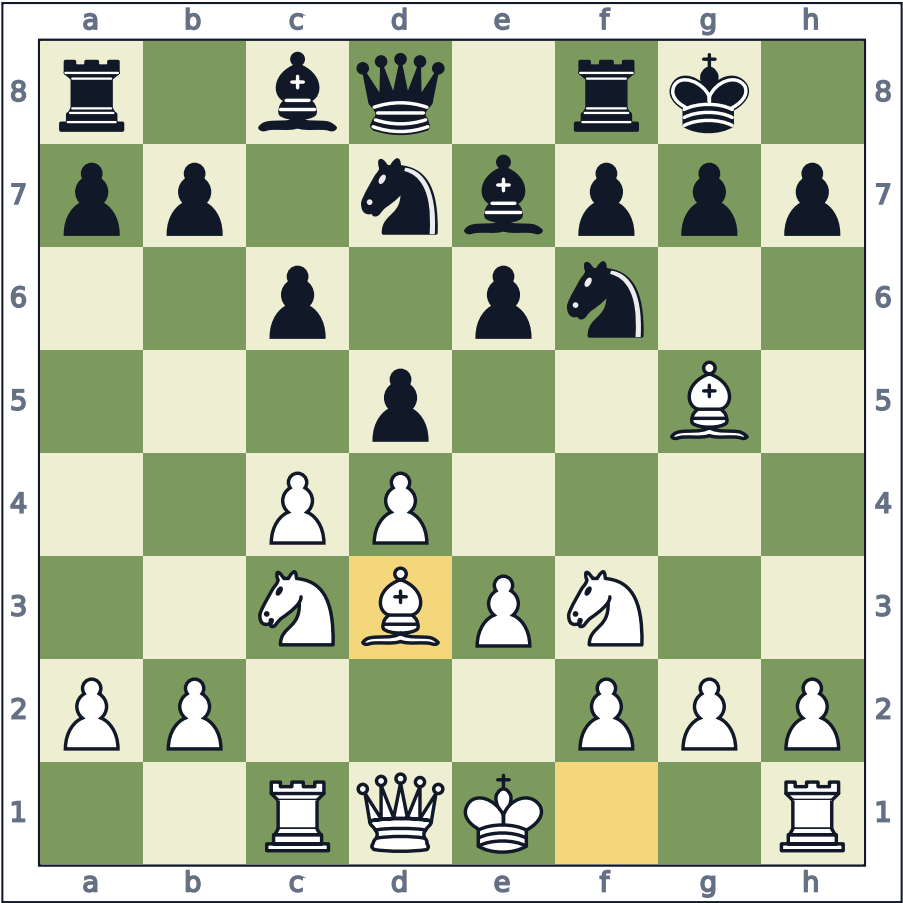


Queen's Gambit Declined

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BOTH SIDES

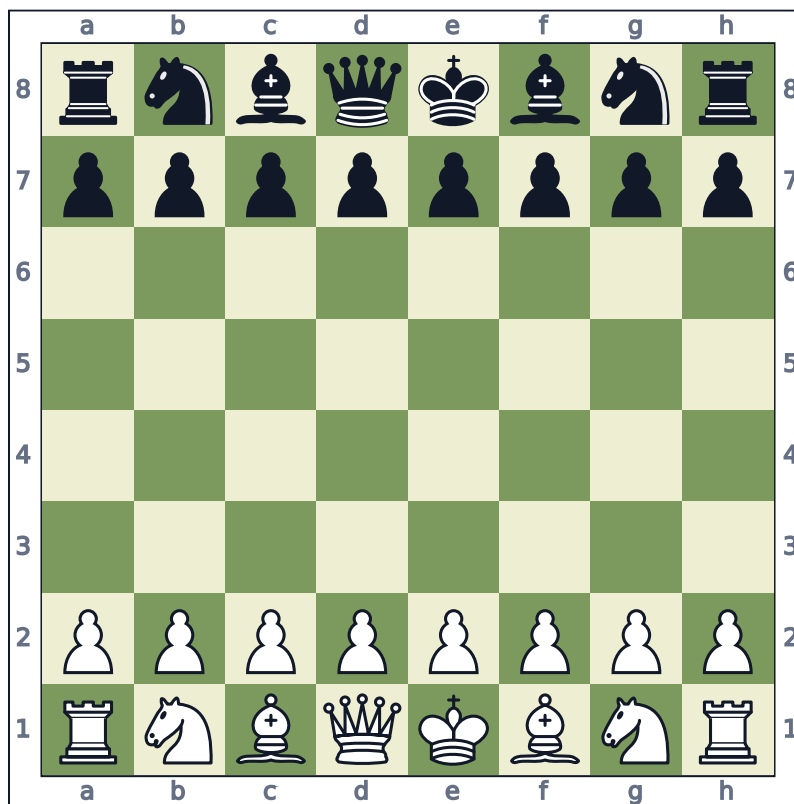
OPENING IDENTITY

Black supports d5 with e6, accepting temporary limits on the light bishop.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

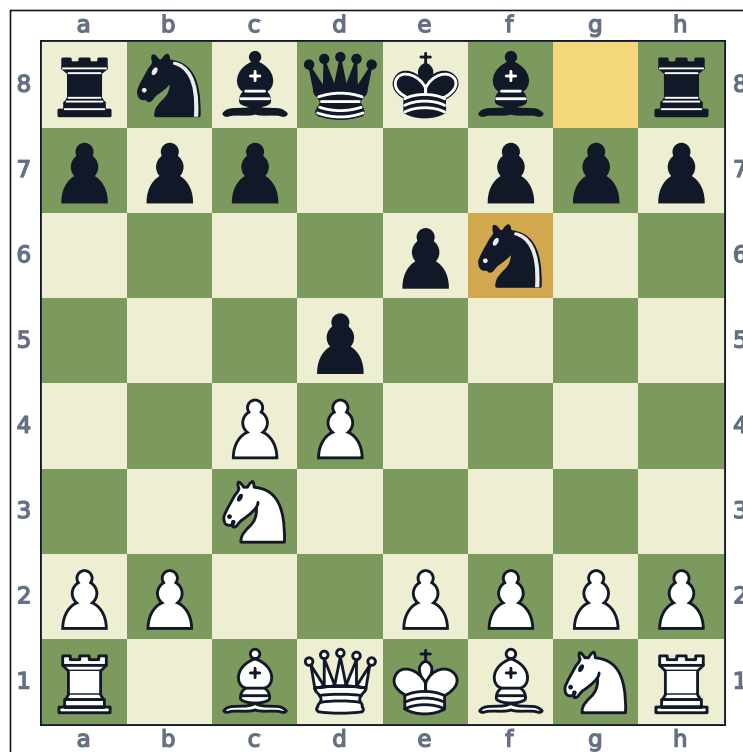
1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

Course promise: Support the center, then free the bishop.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6



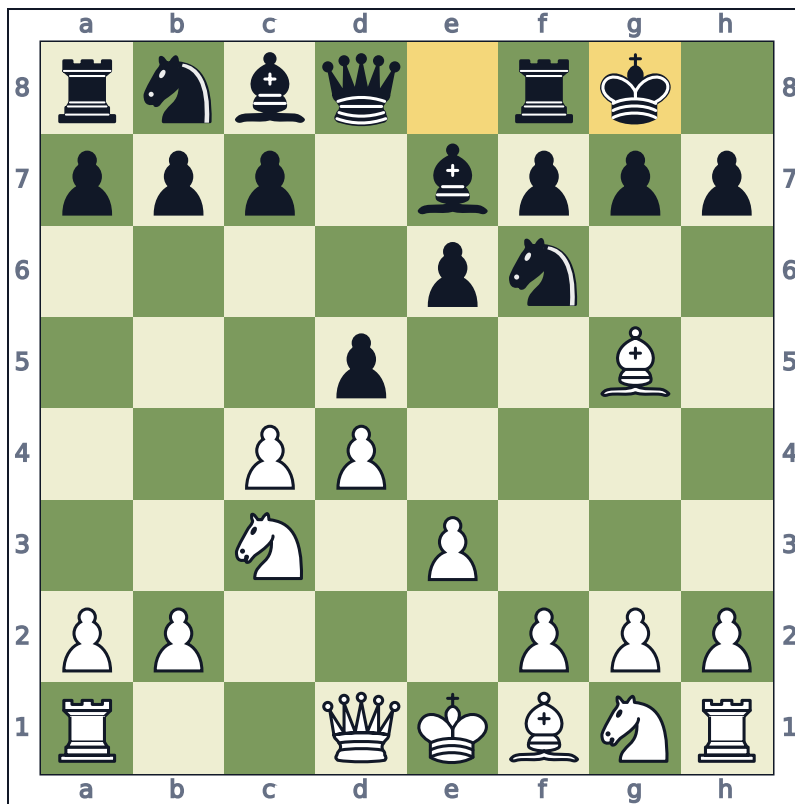
After 3. Nc3 Nf6

- 1. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... d5 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 2. c4 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2... e6 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 3. Nc3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3... Nf6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Black supports d5 with e6, accepting temporary limits on the light bishop.

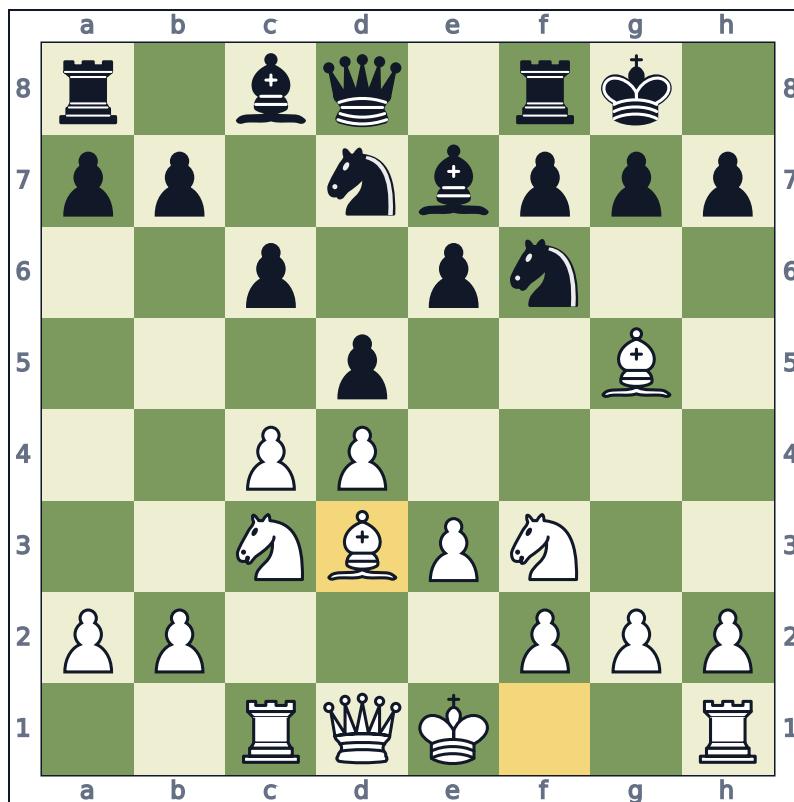
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3



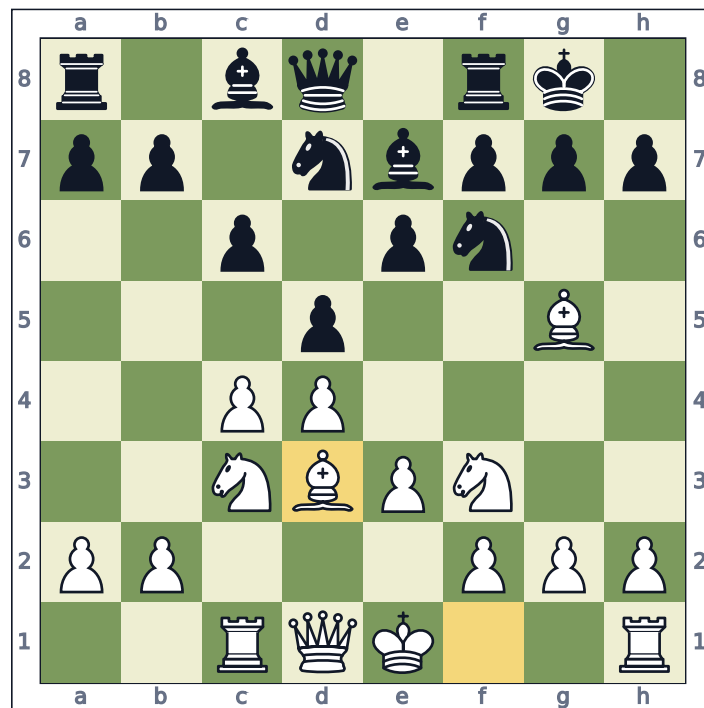
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black supports d5 with e6, accepting temporary limits on the light bishop. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop pressure, choose between $cx d5$ and a maintained tension, and use active piece placement.

BLACK'S PLAN

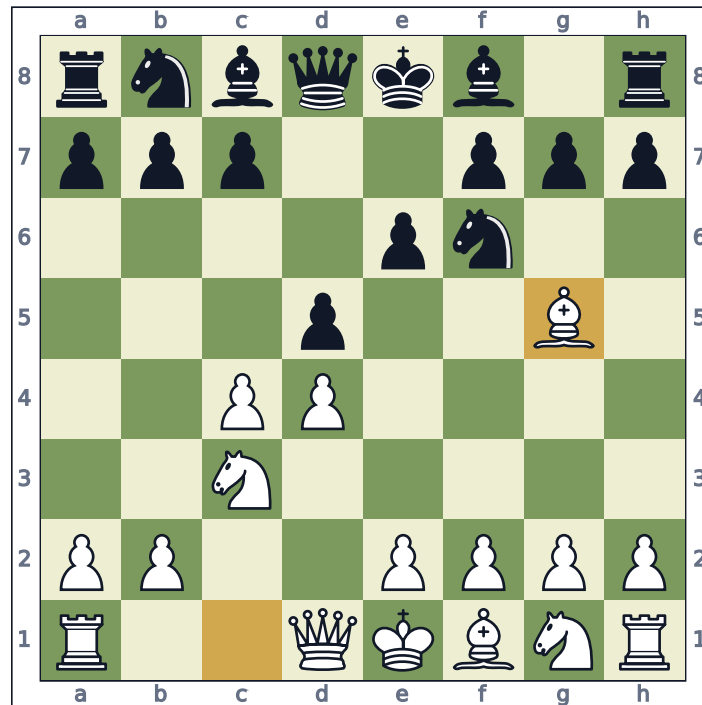
Complete development, prepare $\dots c5$ or $\dots e5$, and solve the c8-bishop.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

$\dots c5$ is the standard freeing break; $\dots e5$ is possible with preparation.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - Black to move

THEME

Pins on f6 can make central captures tactical when the queen sits behind the knight.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

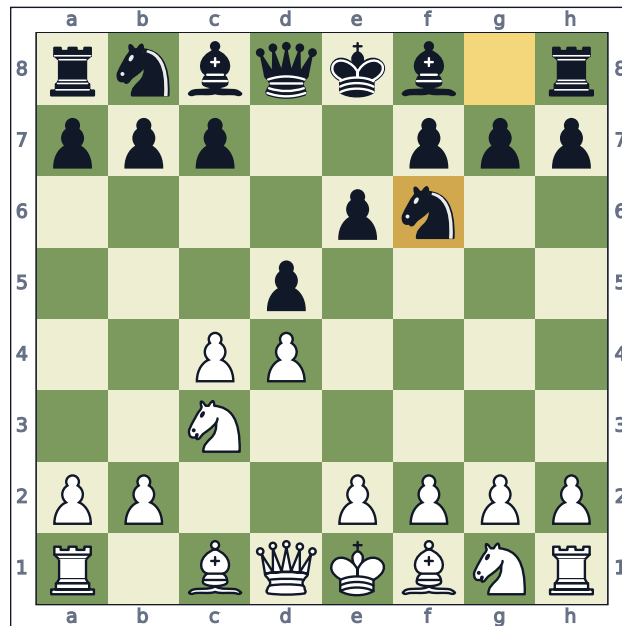
For Black, defending d5 forever instead of freeing the position.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black supports d5 with e6, accepting temporary limits on the light bishop.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: ...c5 is the standard freeing break; ...e5 is possible with preparation.

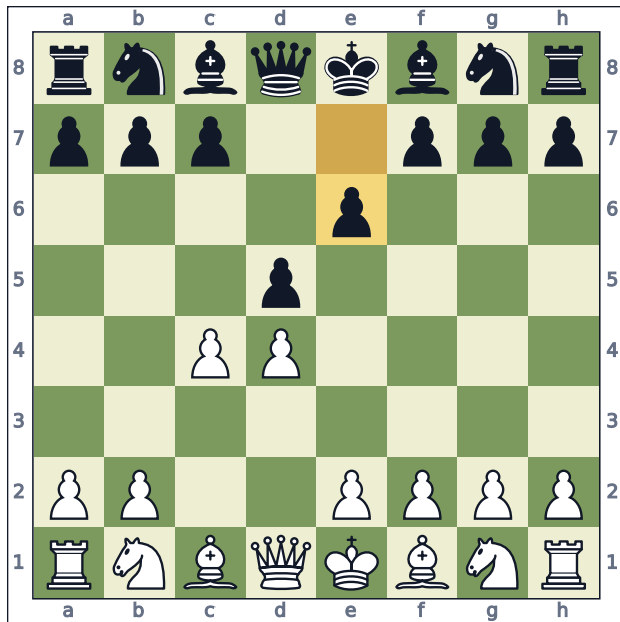
MEMORY SENTENCE

Support the center, then free the bishop.

ACTIVE RECALL

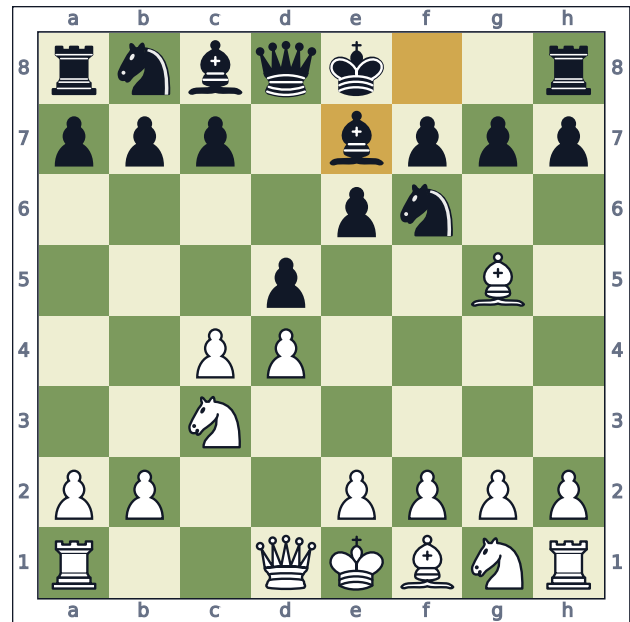
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Nc3. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: e3. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Develop pressure, choose between cxd5 and a maintained tension, and use active piece placement.

Black: Complete development, prepare ...c5 or ...e5, and solve the c8-bishop. Lever: ...c5 is the standard freeing break; ...e5 is possible with preparation.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.